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Robert Campbell Special to The Globe
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By Robert Campbell
Special to The Globe

MINNEAPOLIS — Jose Luis Sert, a former dean of the Harvard School of Design, yesterday attacked most modern architecture as "vulgar and monotonous."

In a speech during ceremonies honoring him with the gold medal of the American Institute of Architects (AIA), the highest American honor in the field, Sert said the modern movement "has a long way to go." But he added that it was still the best hope for a better environment.

Sert, a founder of modern architecture, took a passing cut at the current fashion in architecture known as Post-Modernism, which he called "visions of stage sets." Then he said: "There is a negative attitude among the general public toward modern architecture that is both human and understandable. The majority of modern stuff is vulgar and cheap-looking, monotonous, with box-like flat facades and roofs and curtain walls which are repeated for miles, the same in every city."

Looking small and frail but indomitable at the podium of the vast convention hall here, Sert, 79, received a standing ovation from 2000 architects assembled for the annual AIA convention.

He warned against abandoning the ideals of the modernist revolution and said the problem was that they hadn't been fulfilled.

Sert called the modern movement "50 years of experiments that are a living, if not very attractive, reality." He called for architects not to abandon but rather to learn from these "experi-



JOSE LUIS SERT
"Modern architecture is not dead"

ments" and move on to a better world.

"No. Modern architecture is not dead. It has not yet followed its full course. It is still young and very much alive."

Besides the gold medal, Sert accepted an AIA award for one of his designs, a residential complex on Roosevelt Island in New York.

Among other Sert designs cited in the presentation of the gold medal by AIA President R. Randall Vosbeck were the Peabody Terrace apartments at Harvard and the Harvard Science Center. Sert and the firm of Sert, Jackson and Associates also designed a library, student union and classroom tower for Boston University, dormitories for MIT, the Holyoke Center in Harvard Square and other works in the United

States and Europe.

In an interview, videotaped for the AIA archives prior to his speech yesterday, Sert reminisced about his youth in Barcelona. He recalled close friendships in Paris with artists such as Pablo Picasso, Joan Miro, and Alexander Calder, all of whom worked with Sert in the design of the Spanish Pavilion at the Paris World Fair of 1937, at which Picasso's celebrated mural "Guernica" was exhibited.

Sert recalled that he came to America in 1939, after the Franco government in Spain revoked his architect's license. He had few commissions, he said, until his appointment as dean at Harvard in 1953. "That changed my whole life."

Two previous AIA Gold Medalists, I. M. Pei and Buckminster Fuller, are scheduled to debate with Sert tomorrow on the convention's theme, "Design and Energy."

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